A Major

Scale Practice Worksheet · Three sharps (F♯, C♯, G♯) · 4 octaves

Hand position

Imagine a small ball under each hand — always feel as if holding something. The fingers are like small hooks. The knuckles stick out. There is a natural arch from the elbow through the forearm to the hand. The fingers are very active; the hands remain flexible and free. Play on the little pillows at the fingertips. The most important thing is to avoid tensing any muscles — that is the secret of high quality technique.

FLAT FINGERS

Avoid flat fingers — they reduce speed. The faster the intended tempo, the closer the hand sits to the keyboard. Even great pianists like Horowitz played with a flatter hand, but the general rule is: learn the correct arched position first, then you can do whatever you like.

SCALES

01 Scale

Play A major across 4 octaves. A major has three sharps: F♯, C♯, G♯. Note the 4th finger positions: `left hand 4th finger on B`, `right hand 4th finger on G♯`. An optional right-hand starting fingering is to begin on the 2nd finger.

02 Scale in Octaves

Play A major in octaves across 4 octaves, parallel and contrary motion.

03 Scale in Thirds

Play A major in thirds across 4 octaves.

04 Double Thirds

Play A major in double thirds (two voices a third apart, both hands simultaneously) across the keyboard. The goal is to play as legato as possible.

Starting fingering: RH 1/3 LH 5/3

5th finger on: RH — E and B LH — A and D

2nd finger on: RH — F# LH — G#

Getting the fingering wrong in double thirds compounds immediately — establish it correctly before building tempo.

Practice method: Remove one voice entirely and play only the remaining single line. This isolates each voice and trains evenness before combining.

ARPEGGIOS & BROKEN CHORDS

05 Broken Chords

Play A major broken chords across the full keyboard. One inversion begins on a black key — isolate that inversion and practice it separately before combining.

TECHNIQUE

Use a rotation movement through the wrist rather than stretching or reaching for each key. Prolong the third note of every group as a rhythmic variation to reinforce the rotation.

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06 Long Arpeggios

Play **E – G♯ – B – D** as long arpeggios across the full keyboard, as legato as possible. Work through root position, 1st, 2nd, and 3rd inversions. Contrary motion can be applied to each inversion in turn — a good coordination exercise.

Fingering rule: In the right hand, place the thumb on the first white key of each group. In the left hand, place the thumb on the last white key of each group.

> **TIP**
> The 2nd inversion is particularly uncomfortable due to very different distances between fingers. Practice the hand shape slowly before adding tempo.

07 Dominant in Octaves

Play the dominant chord in octaves across the keyboard, parallel and contrary motion. Place the `4th finger on the black key` and the `5th finger on the white key`.

VARIATIONS

Contrary Motion

Any scale or arpeggio exercise can be played in contrary motion — one hand ascending while the other descends simultaneously.

Accent & Rhythmic Variations

Apply to any scale or arpeggio exercise:

a Accent every note.

b Accent every second note.

c Triplet groupings.

GENERAL PRACTICE PRINCIPLES

- Start slow to warm up; increase tempo only when the hands feel loose
- In slow practice, exaggerate movements so the hand learns the shape; movements shrink naturally at speed
- Practice left hand alone at tempo — the right hand conceals left-hand weakness
- Play at a fast tempo to expose imperfections, then isolate and fix them
- Comfort is the measure — if it doesn't feel comfortable, the technique needs attention